

Ἀφθόνιος Ἀντιοχεὺς ὁ Σύρος

Aphthonius of Antioch and the Preliminary Exercises of Rhetoric

eul_aid: txi

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)
Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα τεχνική [Atticizing Technical](#)
Domain: Ῥητορική [Oratory](#)
Format: Λόγος [Oration](#)
Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Aphthonius of Antioch was a Greek teacher of rhetoric, or sophist, who lived and worked in the late 4th century CE. He came from Syria and was a student of the famous orator Libanius in Antioch. As a sophist, his profession involved teaching the art of public speaking and composing formal speeches for display, a common career for educated elites in the late Roman Empire, though the specific details of his public life are not recorded.

His lasting importance comes from a single surviving work: a textbook called the Progymnasmata. This book outlines fourteen standard preliminary exercises used to train students in rhetoric, such as writing fables, narratives, and short arguments. Its clear organization and practical examples made it an exceptionally influential teaching tool. It became a fundamental textbook for centuries, used throughout the Byzantine period and into early modern Europe to teach the foundational skills of composition and argument.

Through this manual, Aphthonius played a key role in transmitting the techniques of classical Greek rhetoric to later generations. His work is often studied alongside similar handbooks by other ancient rhetoricians as a crucial part of the educational tradition.

Works (1)

- Προγυμνάσματα · [Preliminary Exercises](#) · 51 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- Ἀχιλλεὺς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · [Achilles Tattius of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός · [Aelian of Praeneste](#) · 4 works
- Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος · [Aelius Aristides of Smyrna](#) · 3 works
- Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς · [Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus](#) · 1 work
- Αἴλιος Θεών ὁ σοφιστής · [Aelius Theon the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς · [Alcidamas of Elaea](#) · 1 work
- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · [Alciphron the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · [Alexander Son of Numenius](#) · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · [Alexander the Ephesian Poet](#) · 1 work

- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Antiphon of Athens · 9 works